CHANNELLING YOUTH POWER

India's vast young population presents opportunities for nation-building. Sporting triumphs are an index

By KAUSHIK DEKA

India has an estimated 254 million of its population aged 15–24 years, the highest globally. The ministry of sports and youth affairs, thus, plays a crucial role in harnessing this demographic's potential for nation-building and economic growth through various schemes, events and organisations. These include the National Service Scheme and the Mera Yuva Bharat (MY Bharat) programme, which aim to train youth in leadership skills and the spirit of volunteering. While Indian sportspersons have achieved global glory in recent years, supported by initiatives like TOPS (Target Olympic Podium Scheme) and Khelo India, some sports federations have been embroiled in controversies over malpractices and political influences. It is crucial to take a holistic approach and involve all stakeholders to create a thriving sports ecosystem before India can aspire to host the Olympics. ■

MANSUKH MANDAVIYA
Minister of Youth Affairs & Sports

Minister of State



RAKSHA NIKHIL KHADSE, *37* | BJP

↘ **Sheer dedication** Raksha was just 26 when she entered the Lok Sabha from Raver in Maharashtra in 2014, a year after she lost her husband. A mother of two, she has retained the seat since then; is second youngest minister in Modi 3.0

WHAT NEEDS TO BE DONE

IMPLEMENT LABOUR CODES
Get states to formulate guidelines and implement the four codes on industrial relations, social security, wages and occupational safety, health and working conditions, enacted in 2019-20. They are key to labour law reforms

APPRENTICESHIP PROGRAMMES
As per industry estimates, India will need over 20 million apprentices in the next few years. The system needs to be simplified. A revamp of the National Career Service portal will help connect the job seekers and providers more effectively

RIGHT SKILLS FOR THE JOB
Further incentivise the private sector to increase its demand for labour. At the same time, Mandaviya should work in tandem with the skill development & entrepreneurship minister to ensure that prospective workers are receiving the right education and skills training

FEMALE PARTICIPATION
The female labour force participation rate improved by 4.2 percentage points, reaching 37 per cent in 2023. The ministry should continue making efforts to impart skills and create jobs for women besides ensuring an enabling environment offering improved working conditions

WHAT NEEDS TO BE DONE

National Policy
The National Youth Policy 2021 envisaging action in major areas for youth development, including experiential learning, leadership, health, fitness and social inclusion, is still stuck in consultations. Develop a comprehensive implementation plan with clear timelines, dedicated funding, and measurable targets to ensure its successful execution

Governance Reforms
Initiate a comprehensive review of the existing governance structures of sports bodies to free them from the clutches of politicians and instil professionalism

Widen the Ambit
Explore the inclusion of additional sports, particularly those with a strong regional or local following, in Khelo India Youth Games to provide a broader platform to budding athletes

Make Career Pathways
Establish partnerships with private and public sector organisations to create and provide educational and employment opportunities to sportspersons